NKS CAPITAL

THE EXECUTIVE ASSISTANT'S COMPLETE GUIDE

Professional Support and Protective Coordination

LEARNING UNIT

02

Professional Boundaries, Ethics and Limits of Authority

Judgement. Integrity. Dignity. Safe limits.

A complete learning-unit manuscript with worked decisions, practical tools and explanatory guidance.

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Executive Protection Training Programme

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Primary outcome: EA-02. Seven supporting outcomes connect the explanations, worked decisions, practical tools and unit practice task.

A note to the reader

Professional boundaries are not a retreat from responsibility. They make responsibility usable. A capable Executive Assistant can recognise a legitimate need, identify the limits of a proposed action and keep appropriate assistance moving without pretending to hold powers, qualifications or information that have not been provided.

Learning Unit 1 established the executive-EA partnership. This unit develops the decisions that protect that partnership when a request is sensitive, ambiguous or inappropriate. The primary outcome is EA-02: evaluate requests against the EA mandate and supplied policy requirements, then act, obtain approval, refer or decline and escalate without exceeding professional boundaries. [R1; R2]

The Meridian examples continue with Lindiwe, the executive; Daniel, the EA; Thandi, the EPO; and Aisha, the deputy. All people, events, permissions and service arrangements are fictional. New case developments are identified explicitly. The four response categories, decision tools and dialogue are original teaching methods, not statutory classifications or existing NKS procedures. [R3]

This is professional-development material, not legal advice, clinical instruction or a protection qualification. South African legal references provide limited context, not a complete jurisdictional compliance review. Apply current, reviewed local procedures at work. Do not delay essential emergency help for a routine approval or form. Use fictional information in the exercises; actual contacts, private records, live movements and confidential alert arrangements belong in restricted organisational procedures.

What you will be able to demonstrate

Outcome	Performance to demonstrate
EA-02.1	Classify a request as independently authorised, requiring approval, belonging to a specialist, or outside the EA role as taught, including requests made by a senior executive.
EA-02.2	Distinguish ordinary call handling from recording or interception, and authorised information-exposure awareness from covert tracking or access to personal accounts.
EA-02.3	Identify when a request for executive, family, health or location information exceeds the recipient's verified authority or legitimate need.
EA-02.4	Distinguish first-aid-kit readiness and arranging medical assistance from practical first aid, diagnosis, medication decisions and treatment beyond separate competence and authority.
EA-02.5	Recognise protective searches, restraint, weapons, tactical driving, private investigation, rescue planning and hostage negotiation as outside this EA course.
EA-02.6	Refer incident command, formal family liaison, public statements and specialist legal, medical or protective decisions to the designated authorised person.
EA-02.7	Respond to an unsafe or unauthorised instruction with a respectful explanation, a safer alternative and appropriate escalation; do not let routine approval steps delay essential emergency help.

The principal evidence is a reasoned boundary-decision record. It must show the requested action, the permitted response, the reason, the next responsible person and the safer alternative. A label such as 'not my job' is not sufficient. [R2, EA-02]

2.1 Why boundaries belong at the centre of the role

2.1.1 The request behind the request

On another morning at the fictional Meridian Services, Daniel receives a request from a conference organiser: 'Please send the complete executive information file so that we can make the visit seamless.' The organiser is someone he has worked with before. The request sounds helpful. The file, however, includes much more than the organiser needs: private contact information, a historical itinerary and material prepared for different support functions.

At almost the same time, a colleague suggests leaving an online meeting assistant running during a discussion that Daniel will not attend. 'It will save you writing the minutes afterwards,' the colleague says. A third message asks him to confirm that an unfamiliar venue is secure because he has already made the booking. None of these requests arrives with the appearance of a dramatic security incident. Each arrives as an invitation to be useful.

The difficulty lies in the method, not necessarily the intention. The organiser may need an arrival time and an accessibility arrangement, not the complete file. The meeting needs an accurate record, not necessarily an unapproved recording or external transcription service. The executive needs a workable venue, but a booking confirmation is not a protective assessment. Daniel can support all three legitimate needs while challenging the proposed actions.

A useful first question is therefore: what is the person trying to achieve, and is there a properly authorised way to achieve it? This question prevents two opposite failures. Uncritical compliance treats every proposed method as acceptable. Blanket refusal treats a problem with the method as a reason to abandon the need. Professional judgement separates them.

2.1.2 Responsibility needs a boundary

A boundary defines the extent of a responsibility, permission or professional function. It tells the assistant where independent action ends, what conditions must be met and who owns the next decision. It also protects colleagues from an inaccurate impression that the executive office has approved something that it has merely received or arranged.

Think back to the working agreement in LU1. Daniel may coordinate appointments, prepare papers and communicate approved arrangements. That does not make him the owner of every underlying decision. Finance retains its payment process. Thandi retains the protective input assigned to her. The control room retains responsibility for accepting monitoring within its service mandate. These responsibilities meet at interfaces; they do not merge into a single unlimited EA role. [R3, section 1.7]

Boundaries also make appropriate independence possible. An assistant should not seek fresh permission for every routine action already delegated under clear conditions. A carefully bounded mandate allows reliable action within those conditions. The aim is neither habitual permission-seeking nor habitual improvisation. It is accurate recognition of the situation in front of you.

A boundary becomes practically useful when it can answer a concrete question. May I move this meeting? May I release this information to this person for this purpose? May I agree this cost? May I say that the monitoring assignment has been accepted? The answer often depends on a condition, not on the general name of the task. 'Travel administration' might include arranging a quotation but not accepting an uninsured or unapproved commitment.

> **KEY POINT | A boundary protects the service**
>
> A professional response preserves the legitimate need while controlling the action. Explain what can proceed, what cannot proceed yet, what belongs elsewhere and who must decide.

2.1.3 Four ideas that must not be confused

Authority is permission to make a decision or perform an action within a defined scope. Competence is the capability to perform it to the required standard. Access is the ability to reach a record, system, place or person. Accountability concerns who must answer for the decision or performance. They are connected, but one does not prove the others.

Daniel may be able to open a folder because its permissions were configured broadly. That access does not establish a purpose for reading every file or permission to forward it. He may have attended an awareness course about medical emergencies. That learning does not establish practical first-aid competence. He may be asked to coordinate an EPO's availability. That administrative responsibility does not make him the commander of a protective operation.

The reverse matters too. A person may have the relevant qualification but no current appointment to perform a particular organisational role. An EA who separately holds a professional credential does not obtain unrestricted authority through the EA course. Any genuinely combined role needs its own current competence, lawful authority, appointment, resources and operating procedures. Record which role is being exercised; do not let responsibilities change invisibly halfway through a task.

This distinction avoids an overstatement: the book does not declare every specialist action unlawful for every person in every circumstance. It defines what this EA course teaches and authorises no specialist action by itself. Legal rights, emergency duties and professional requirements need their own current application.

2.1.4 What good boundaries look like in ordinary work

Good boundaries are visible in wording. 'I have booked the venue' is different from 'the venue has been assessed and accepted by the appointed security lead'. 'I have passed on the request' is different from 'the responsible person has accepted it'. 'The device last reported here' is different from 'the executive is safe here now'. Each distinction keeps a factual statement within its evidence.

They are also visible in behaviour. A familiar caller goes through the applicable verification process. A colleague receives the version appropriate to their task rather than the whole background file. A missing approval remains an open dependency. A deputy receives individual authorised access rather than a shared password. None of this requires suspicion of everyone; it requires consistency about what is known and permitted.

The standard protects the assistant as well as the executive. Do not make personal confrontation, permanent availability or unnecessary intrusion into family life a test of loyalty. The companion tiger-kidnapping guide places people before assets and explicitly rejects private surveillance, confrontation and rescue activity. This unit retains that educational boundary. [A1, chapter 1]

Reflection 1. In the organiser's request for the complete executive file, identify the legitimate need, the proposed action and a narrower response. Which facts would you need before sharing anything?

2.2 Deciding whether to act, obtain approval, refer or decline

2.2.1 Start with safety, then define the action

The decision method begins with a safety check. Is someone in credible immediate danger or asking for urgent emergency help? If so, use the appropriate emergency route as safely as possible. Routine classification, an unavailable manager or a blank form must not delay essential assistance. The purpose of the following questions is to guide judgement, not to create an obstacle between a person and help. [R1, sections 7-8; R2, EA-02.7]

For ordinary requests, define the action in a complete sentence. 'Help with the visit' is too broad. 'Send the host the approved arrival time and meeting contact' is assessable. 'Give the host a copy of the executive's private emergency profile' is a different action. Dividing a mixed request into its components often reveals that part can proceed while another part needs approval or referral.

Next, identify the authority for that action. Look to the current working agreement, delegated authority, policy or accepted procedure. Determine whose information, funds, premises, professional responsibility or service commitment is involved. A request from one person cannot automatically supply another person's permission or another organisation's capacity.

Finally, establish what conditions apply and whether they are satisfied. A pre-approved activity may still depend on using the approved provider, staying within a budget, verifying a recipient or obtaining specialist input for a material change. Do not treat the broad approval as permission to discard its conditions.

2.2.2 The four response categories

The categories below are a course decision aid. They describe the primary disposition of a particular action at a particular time. A complex request may contain actions in several categories. The classifications are not ranks, legal verdicts or a substitute for the actual mandate.

Category	Meaning in this course	What the EA does next
A - Independently authorised	The action falls within the current mandate; relevant conditions and competence are established.	Perform the bounded task, make any required record and confirm the result.
B - Approval required	The action may be legitimate, but the necessary authority, condition or change approval is missing.	Prepare the decision, identify the proper approver and keep the action pending until the required conditions are met.
C - Specialist-owned	The substantive judgement or operation belongs to an appointed specialist or designated function.	Refer to that owner and perform only the authorised administrative support around the task.
D - Outside the EA role as taught	The proposed action exceeds the course role or involves an improper method, such as falsifying a record or covert access.	Do not perform the proposed action; explain or safely report the concern and support a legitimate alternative.

A Category B action is not a promise that approval will make it acceptable. The appropriate owner may refuse it, require legal review, change its scope or identify it as Category C or D. An executive's signature cannot manufacture clinical competence or cure an unlawful instruction. Equally, an action does not become Category D merely because it is unfamiliar; the learner should identify the actual missing authority or competence.

Category C and Category D often meet. Performing a protective search is outside the EA role taught. Assessing whether and how an authorised search may occur belongs to the appropriate specialist within law and mandate. For a precise record, describe the requested EA action as D and the legitimate referral as C. This is more informative than arguing over one label for an entire event.

2.2.3 Law, policy, agreement and preference

A practical distinction is needed between a legal requirement, an organisational rule, a delegated permission and a personal preference. The working agreement operates within applicable law and organisational requirements. An executive's preference can guide choices that remain available; it is not a general override of those requirements.

The assistant does not need to issue a legal opinion whenever a question arises. Instead, recognise triggers for qualified review: recording a meeting involving private participants, collecting new categories of health or family information, broadening location monitoring or sending sensitive records to a new provider or country. Describe the proposed activity and ask the designated legal or privacy owner for an operational instruction that the EA can follow.

Not every internal rule is the law. Saying 'that is illegal' without a sound basis can damage trust and conceal the real issue. A more accurate statement may be: 'I do not have authority under the current arrangement to release that record. I will refer the request to the information owner.' Reserve a claim about legality for an applicable, verified requirement or qualified advice.

A procedure must not be used to conceal abuse or prevent lawful reporting. Nor should the assistant improvise a legal entitlement or promise protection that has not been established. Where a concern involves the person who would ordinarily approve the work, use the alternative independent reporting route identified in the organisation's arrangements and seek appropriate advice where necessary.

2.2.4 A worked classification

Suppose Lindiwe asks Daniel to arrange an internal preparation meeting, confirm a new external venue and release a supplier payment. The current fictional agreement permits routine internal meeting changes when no protected time, cost or specialist dependency is affected. Daniel can perform that bounded scheduling task once those conditions are checked.

The new venue is different. Lindiwe can state the business preference, but Thandi must provide the required protective input, the relevant owners must authorise any cost, and the control room must accept any changed monitoring scope. Daniel can gather information and prepare the request. He cannot collapse these different decisions into one statement that 'the executive approved everything'.

Payment release remains with finance under the LU1 fictional agreement. Daniel can check the request's administrative completeness and send it through the approved route. He may not use access to the executive's messages as a substitute for financial authority. If asked to describe an unverified

payment change as verified, the specific false statement is outside the role, not a routine exception awaiting a senior signature.

FIRST: IMMEDIATE SAFETY	THEN: DEFINE THE ACTION	CHOOSE THE RESPONSE	COMPLETE THE CONNECTION
Activate appropriate urgent help safely; do not wait for routine administration.	Identify the exact task, mandate, conditions and missing facts.	Act within authority; obtain approval; refer; or decline the improper action.	Record the real status and confirm an owner, outcome or accepted transfer.

Figure 2.1 - A bounded response. Original course teaching model; apply the actual mandate and emergency procedure.

2.2.5 Proportionate records, not permission rituals

Record decisions in proportion to their significance. A routine scheduling task may already have sufficient evidence in the approved calendar and task system. A sensitive disclosure, disputed instruction or unaccepted monitoring task needs a clearer record of the facts, authority, conditions and next owner. The purpose is a reliable history, not a growing archive of unnecessary personal detail.

A useful record separates the request from the decision and the decision from execution. It states who authorised what, when and under which conditions. A later correction should retain the earlier status rather than silently rewriting it. 'Approval received at 10:20; no disclosure before that time' is more useful than a general tick under 'approved'.

Reflection 2. A request contains one permitted administrative action and one specialist action. How would you keep the permitted work moving without implying that you have accepted the specialist responsibility?

2.3 Ethics, dignity and professional integrity

2.3.1 Loyalty is not unquestioning compliance

In the professional model used in this book, loyalty means supporting the executive's legitimate objectives with honesty, discretion and sound judgement. It does not mean disguising an error, concealing a conflict of interest or obtaining information through an improper route. A useful assistant brings uncomfortable facts to the right person before those facts become an avoidable surprise.

Consider a request to change the time on an acknowledgement so that a late handover appears timely. The proposed change may be presented as administrative tidying rather than dishonesty. Its effect, however, is to tell future readers that someone accepted responsibility before they actually did. That changes the apparent period of coverage and obscures the gap the organisation needs to understand.

Daniel's task is to preserve the real sequence and obtain a correction through the authorised process. He can add a factual explanation, identify the late acceptance and help improve the handover method. He should not manufacture an earlier approval. A record that exposes an uncomfortable gap is more useful to responsible management than one that hides it.

The same principle applies to minutes, supplier checks and incident notes. Distinguish a proposal from an agreed decision. Do not attribute words to an executive because they seem likely. Do not

transform a colleague's recollection into a confirmed event. The record should allow uncertainty to be resolved without pretending it never existed.

2.3.2 Fair treatment without stereotyping

A visitor's confidence, clothing, accent, nationality, gender or social position should not substitute for the approved access and verification process. In this course, learners assess the request, the claimed role, the relevant behaviour and the evidence. The companion guide makes the same distinction between observable conduct and assumptions about identity. [A1, chapters 2 and 7]

This matters in ordinary administration as well as protective coordination. A well-known supplier may press for an exception; a new employee may be less comfortable explaining a request. Apply the process consistently while communicating respectfully. Consistency does not require an identical conversation with every person. An accessibility need may require a different communication method without lowering the relevant verification standard.

Privacy and dignity also apply to the assistant. Personal errands should not become an unspoken obligation merely because an executive is influential. A request that affects private life, physical safety or professional integrity deserves a clear scope discussion. The person raising a concern should not be required to endure humiliation as evidence of dedication.

A factual report should describe what happened without diagnosing intention. 'The caller asked for a private address after I explained that the request needed verification' is useful. 'The caller is obviously dangerous' is an unsupported conclusion unless qualified evidence establishes it. Neutral reporting allows the appropriate team to assess a concern while treating everyone fairly.

2.3.3 Gifts, relationships and competing interests

A conflict of interest may arise where a private benefit or relationship could influence a work decision. The practical course rule is to disclose relevant connections through the designated process and avoid making an affected decision independently. This is not a universal monetary threshold or a complete anti-corruption legal guide; apply the employer's current rules.

Suppose a preferred event supplier offers Daniel a personal weekend stay while he is arranging a venue comparison. The assistant should not solve the issue by deciding privately that the value is modest or that the offer has no effect on him. He should make the required disclosure and obtain the designated decision before accepting any benefit. The venue comparison should retain its proper business criteria and decision owner.

Similarly, if a family member runs a transport business, the EA can disclose that relationship rather than silently directing work to the business. The relevant procurement and protective checks still apply. Referring a supplier for consideration is not the same as certifying suitability, waiving verification or approving payment.

The lesson is broader than gifts. Privileged access must not be used to obtain favours, silence a colleague or imply commercial authority that has not been delegated. The executive office should provide a clear route for legitimate work, not an informal system of influence.

2.3.4 Confidentiality is not concealment

Confidentiality means controlling information appropriately. Concealment means suppressing a material fact that should reach the authorised decision or reporting process. They can be confused when someone says, 'Keep this between us.' The phrase might concern a legitimate sensitive

discussion, or it might be an attempt to prevent a concern reaching its proper owner. Clarify the purpose and applicable route.

Do not promise absolute secrecy. A colleague who discloses a serious concern may need safety support or referral. Explain, as far as circumstances allow, that information will be limited to those who need it for the appropriate response. Avoid gathering a detailed personal history merely to decide where to refer the person.

The South African Department of Employment and Labour's public guidance emphasises confidentiality in handling harassment concerns while noting that confidentiality does not prevent appropriate steps to protect employee safety or dignity. That is a limited contextual reference, not a determination of any learner's case or a promise about available remedies. [S4]

For course practice, a safe response is to acknowledge the report, identify immediate support needs, explain the reporting options available in the supplied policy and help connect the person to an appropriate owner. Do not investigate the allegation, require a confrontation, decide that it is unfounded or promise a particular employment outcome.

> **BOUNDARY | Integrity is more than declining a request**
>
> Preserve an accurate record, disclose a relevant conflict and use an appropriate reporting route. Do not make the executive's reputation, your own convenience or a tidy dashboard the reason to hide a material concern.

Reflection 3. A colleague asks you to backdate a handover acknowledgement because 'the room would have been watching anyway'. What fact would the changed record falsely imply, and what correction is appropriate instead?

2.4 Calls, recordings, digital tools and monitoring

2.4.1 What 'calls monitoring' means in this course

The brainstorm used the term 'calls monitoring'. The research deliberately translated that into professional call handling, verification, message management and escalation. It did not grant authority to listen to private conversations or record them. Preserve that distinction when the course is applied in a workplace. [R1, section 8]

Ordinary call handling may involve identifying the caller's stated purpose, recording an appropriate callback route, checking the intended recipient and passing on a message through the approved system. Sensitive requests need the required independent verification before information or access is released. The assistant should not confirm an executive's whereabouts, family circumstances or private appointments simply to keep the conversation friendly.

A useful response is: 'I can take the purpose of your call and arrange the appropriate contact. I cannot confirm private schedule details on this call.' This does not accuse the caller of wrongdoing. It states the limit and offers a legitimate next step. If the call concerns an emergency, identify and activate the appropriate help rather than treating it as an ordinary diary enquiry.

Record only the message needed for the task. A call note is not a verbatim transcript, a clinical assessment or a statement that the caller's claims are true. Use wording such as 'caller stated' where appropriate, identify what has actually been verified and avoid unnecessary sensitive detail in a widely visible task record.

2.4.2 Recording is a separate decision

South Africa's Regulation of Interception of Communications and Provision of Communication-Related Information Act, commonly called RICA, contains a general prohibition and specified exceptions. Its provisions distinguish participation in a communication, prior written consent in specified circumstances and certain business-related interception subject to conditions. The existence of an exception is not blanket permission for an EA recording programme. Applicable law, purpose, authority, privacy and the proposed technology need review. [S2, sections 2 and 4-6]

The practical boundary is therefore not the inaccurate claim that all recording is always prohibited, nor the equally unreliable claim that a company may record anything it owns. For this course, recording or interception is outside routine call-handling authority unless a separately reviewed and authorised arrangement applies to the actual situation. Other jurisdictions may differ; do not carry a South African summary into an international meeting as a universal rule.

A workplace instruction needs to tell the assistant what is permitted, who has approved it, which participants and communications are covered, what notice or other conditions apply, where the material is stored and who can access it. These are questions for the organisation's responsible owners to settle before the assistant operates the arrangement. A note in the diary saying 'record everything' is not that instruction.

If a participant objects or the meeting changes materially, do not improvise an exception. Follow the approved procedure, refer the change and use a legitimate alternative where available. An agreed written minute may meet the business purpose without creating a recording. Any existing recording should be handled under the relevant retention and incident process, not casually deleted to make an awkward situation disappear.

2.4.3 Transcription and AI do not remove the boundary

A tool described as a note-taker, meeting assistant or productivity service still needs an approved use. The label does not answer what information will be captured, which people will receive it or where it will go. Treat the addition of an automated participant or a new processing service as a decision about the work and information, not merely a convenient personal setting.

In the Meridian example, Daniel is not attending the meeting and has no approved recording arrangement for it. A colleague's suggestion to leave a tool running does not establish consent, legal authority or the right to capture the discussion. Daniel can instead arrange an authorised minute-taker or refer the recording proposal for the necessary review. He should not falsely represent his attendance through an automated participant.

Even an approved tool has a defined scope. Permission to assist with a routine meeting does not automatically extend to a private medical discussion, a confidential investigation or a different client environment. The assistant needs a way to recognise those changes and check the approved boundary. Do not paste real executive, family or incident information into an unapproved tool to obtain a faster answer.

Any generated summary used as an official work product should be checked by a competent, authorised person. In this book's method, draft output remains draft until reviewed. Do not let plausible wording become a source of invented approvals, attributed statements or completed actions. Technology assists the record; it does not supply the authority behind it.

2.4.4 Exposure awareness is not personal surveillance

The research also narrowed 'monitor social media' to authorised awareness of information exposure. An example is noticing that an approved public event announcement unnecessarily reveals live travel arrangements. The EA may raise the concern through the designated communications or security route. This is different from covertly entering an executive's personal account, building a profile of relatives or following people to establish private relationships. [R1, section 8]

A public post does not create an unlimited purpose for collecting, combining or distributing personal information. In the course model, collect only the material necessary to report the relevant exposure through an approved channel. Do not create a permanent personal dossier because information was easy to find. Requests for broader monitoring need defined purpose, lawful authority, scope and specialist review.

An ordinary boundary response might be: 'The public announcement includes an arrival detail that may need review. I will refer the specific item to the communications owner and Thandi. I will not gather unrelated family posts.' This keeps the report focused on the work requirement and avoids suggesting that the EA should investigate the person's life.

Where an account needs legitimate administrative access, use the approved access process and the appropriate owner. Do not ask for a password as a shortcut, use another person's account or try to defeat privacy settings. Familiarity and helpful intent do not turn unauthorised access into professional support.

2.4.5 Movement information requires its own mandate

A remote control room may receive approved movement or status information for a defined protective purpose. That does not make the EA or the provider an unrestricted observer of the executive's private life. The accepted service arrangement must establish what is monitored, for which activities and periods, by whom and under which access and reporting rules. [R1, sections 6-8]

An instruction to obtain location history 'just to check what happened last weekend' is not the same as managing an accepted business-travel assignment. The EA should establish the purpose and authority rather than request an export by habit. A provider's technical ability to produce information does not prove that the request is authorised.

Do not substitute a tracking signal for a welfare check. A device may report a position; the approved process determines what confirmation is required about the person. Report the time and source of information and what remains unknown. Detailed daily monitoring methods belong in LU9; the boundary taught here is to avoid claiming knowledge or permission beyond the record.

Reflection 4. What changes when a colleague proposes an automated meeting transcript instead of a written minute? Identify the approvals and information-handling questions without assuming that all recording is illegal or automatically permitted.

2.5 Information requests, privacy and legitimate need

2.5.1 Three questions before disclosure

A disclosure decision requires more than recognising a name. First, who is the recipient and how has that identity been verified? Second, what legitimate task or authority supports their request? Third, what information is necessary for that task, and through which approved route may it be shared? Each question can produce a different answer.

A verified relative is not automatically entitled to the executive's location. A genuine supplier may need an arrival window but not a home address. An appointed EPO may need current protective information without needing unrestricted access to every private record. A verified emergency responder may need essential facts that should not be withheld merely because the usual administrative approver is unavailable.

Think of disclosure as a specific action: a defined piece of information, given to a defined recipient, for a defined purpose, under a defined authority. This is more disciplined than deciding that an entire person is either 'trusted' or 'untrusted'. Trust matters in a working relationship, but it does not replace the current sharing rule.

VERIFIED RECIPIENT	LEGITIMATE PURPOSE	NECESSARY INFORMATION
Do I know who is receiving the information through the approved verification method?	What current task or authority establishes the need to receive it?	What minimum relevant information and approved channel serve that purpose?

Figure 2.2 - Three questions for a disclosure decision. Original course teaching model; apply the actual mandate and emergency procedure.

2.5.2 The legal context, without turning the EA into a lawyer

For the South African reference setting, POPIA requires lawful processing and purpose-related limits; consent is one of several grounds for processing, not the only one. The Act addresses information quality, security, retention, special personal information, children's information and transfers outside the Republic. Applying those requirements to a particular service needs competent organisational review. An executive's general approval does not settle every person's data rights or every proposed use. [S1, sections 9-22, 26-35 and 72]

The practical course method is to work from an approved information-handling arrangement. The organisation's responsible privacy and legal owners establish the applicable rules. The EA recognises requests that do not fit those rules, records the gap and obtains the appropriate decision. Do not invent a legal basis, promise that a consent form solves everything or assume that an emergency removes every limit on disclosure.

For teaching purposes, the privacy checks in this unit are deliberately concrete. Do you need the whole file? Does this recipient need the medical detail? Is this a current trip or an old itinerary? Can the availability question be answered without explaining a private appointment? Those questions help the

learner recognise unnecessary exposure while leaving legal determinations with the appropriate owner.

2.5.3 Use role-appropriate information, not one universal pack

A single master support record may connect several activities, but it should not be distributed in full to everyone involved. In the course model, prepare information appropriate to each task. The host may need the meeting time, approved attendee names and relevant access arrangements. The transport coordinator may need the agreed collection and destination information. The control room needs the information defined by the accepted monitoring assignment.

The existence of a medical or family contact record does not mean that those details belong in every itinerary. Sensitive information should follow the approved restricted route and be available to the appropriate person when legitimately required. The practical challenge is to avoid both uncontrolled copying and an inaccessible system that fails when authorised assistance is needed.

Consider a conference organiser asking for 'the executive profile'. Daniel should ask which purpose the organiser needs to fulfil. If the request is for an accessible entrance, the relevant arrangement may be communicated without a full clinical history. If a travel document is genuinely required for a specific process, the approved document-handling route should be used instead of attaching a general personal file.

A useful response gives the recipient a way forward: 'I can provide the approved arrival and meeting information. Please identify any additional requirement so that I can confirm the appropriate information and channel.' This limits disclosure without forcing the recipient to guess what support is available.

2.5.4 Family and private-life requests

A familiar voice or family relationship does not by itself answer an information-sharing question. Family arrangements can be complex, and the EA should not become their investigator or mediator. Use the authorised contact and sharing arrangement rather than making assumptions about entitlement, relationships or motives.

If a caller says they are worried because they cannot reach the executive, listen for a potential immediate safety concern and use the approved support route. Do not dismiss concern merely because the caller lacks permission to receive location data. At the same time, do not disclose the location as an improvised way to reassure them. Receiving a concern and releasing protected information are different actions.

An appropriate response might be: 'I can pass your concern to the designated support contact and arrange the approved follow-up. I cannot release private location details on this call.' If credible immediate danger is reported, activate the relevant emergency process and communicate the facts needed for that response. Do not require the caller to solve the organisation's internal paperwork before the concern is heard.

For a routine private appointment, the diary may need only an unavailable period and any separately approved logistical interface. The EA does not need to investigate why the executive is unavailable. Where household administration is genuinely part of the role, define it in the working agreement and apply the same purpose, access and sharing discipline as other sensitive tasks.

2.5.5 When information is wrong, missing or already exposed

Incorrect information can be as harmful to coordination as missing information. When two sources disagree, identify their dates, owners and status. Do not choose the more convenient version merely because it makes the plan look complete. Ask the appropriate owner to resolve the inconsistency and retain an accurate record of the correction.

If information has been misdirected, report the exposure promptly through the approved incident route and follow instructions on containment and preservation. Do not promise that a message recall has removed every copy. Do not delete the evidence of what was sent or privately negotiate silence with the recipient. The privacy or incident owner determines the required response and any formal notification responsibilities.

POPIA's section 22 addresses notification by the responsible party when there are reasonable grounds to believe personal information has been accessed or acquired by an unauthorised person. The learner's course task is prompt internal reporting and factual support, not independently deciding statutory notification or acting as the regulator's liaison without appointment. [S1, section 22]

The record should be useful without becoming a new unnecessary disclosure. Identify the affected record and its controlled location, the recipient, timing and known actions. Avoid copying the sensitive contents into every message about the incident. The same discipline applies to assessment: use fictional records, not a learner's real workplace or family information.

> **BOUNDARY | Identity is not entitlement**
>
> Verification answers who a person is. Authority and legitimate need answer what they may receive. The disclosure still needs an appropriate scope and channel.

Reflection 5. A verified family contact asks for the last seven days of movement history to resolve a private concern. What can the EA do to support the concern without assuming authority to provide that history?

2.6 Protection, venues, access and control-room limits

2.6.1 Coordinating an activity is not commanding it

The EA-EPO-control-room model is a division of connected responsibilities. The EA maintains the administrative plan and coordinates the required information. The EPO provides protective input and performs specialist work within mandate. The independent control room accepts defined monitoring and assistance tasks under its service arrangement. The organisation appoints the relevant business, risk and incident authorities. [R1, section 6]

No role should quietly approve another role's decision. Lindiwe's preference for a lunch venue does not prove that Thandi has assessed the protective implications. Thandi's availability does not prove that the control room has accepted a changed monitoring period. A control-room reference number does not establish that a clinical responder is available or that the EA may direct police action.

The assistant can make these dependencies visible without obstructing ordinary business. State the proposed change, identify the required decisions and ask each owner for the relevant input. If one

element remains unresolved, show that status honestly. Do not announce a fully coordinated arrangement while an essential decision is still outstanding.

This boundary is equally important when the executive wants to proceed despite advice. The EA should refer the conflict through the organisation's approved decision and escalation structure, record the actual instruction and unresolved dependency, and avoid claiming to have accepted risk on someone else's behalf. This book does not authorise an EA to physically prevent an executive from moving or to invent a universal 'stop-work' power.

2.6.2 Venue information versus a protective assessment

An EA may obtain venue information: the business contact, arrival arrangements, accessibility, meeting facilities, administrative access requirements and the availability of the relevant venue liaison. Those facts support the appointed specialist's work. They do not add up to a protective assessment merely because they are presented in a polished checklist.

A hotel employee saying 'we have security' does not establish the scope or suitability of an executive's protective arrangement. Daniel should pass the relevant information to Thandi and obtain the required specialist decision. He should not inspect restricted areas, test security systems, conduct searches or declare that the venue is secure.

The correct status wording matters. 'Venue booking confirmed; protective review pending' is precise. 'Venue approved' is ambiguous unless the record states who approved which aspect. An internal business approval, venue acceptance of a booking and protective acceptance are separate facts. The assistant should not use one as evidence of all three.

Where circumstances change, refer the change rather than assuming an earlier assessment covers it. A different room, entrance, attendance pattern or timing may require the appointed specialist to decide whether the previous arrangement remains applicable. The EA identifies the change; the specialist determines its protective significance.

2.6.3 Appointments are not physical access authority

A calendar entry establishes a planned meeting, not necessarily the right to enter a building or private residence. Use the approved visitor process, including host confirmation and the relevant identity checks. A confident claim that 'the executive knows me' should not silently override those conditions.

For an unscheduled visitor, the assistant can clarify the stated purpose, contact the appropriate host or access owner and communicate a respectful waiting or alternative arrangement. Physical intervention, searches, restraint and confrontation are not part of this EA course. If behaviour creates immediate concern, seek the authorised security or emergency response rather than trying to resolve it personally.

This does not require the assistant to label the visitor dangerous. It requires an accurate distinction between an unverified request and approved access. A useful statement is: 'I do not yet have host confirmation. I will contact the authorised person; please follow the reception process while that is checked.' The applicable venue staff remain responsible for their own access procedures.

The same distinction applies at a residence. An appointment to discuss maintenance does not authorise the assistant to release gate codes or private household information. A request involving a child, family member or domestic employee requires the relevant approved arrangement, not an improvised extension of executive-office authority.

2.6.4 What this EA course excludes

Proposed action	Boundary for the EA	Legitimate support that may remain
Search a person, bag, vehicle or venue for protective purposes.	Do not perform a protective search under this course.	Refer requirements to the appointed security lead; coordinate authorised access and information.
Carry or use a weapon, restrain someone or confront a suspected offender.	No such operational competence or authority is conferred.	Seek safety and authorised assistance; communicate relevant observed facts.
Perform evasive or tactical driving.	Driving tactics are outside the EA curriculum.	Arrange an approved competent transport provider and refer changes.
Follow a person, inspect a private location or investigate a suspected threat.	Do not undertake private investigative or surveillance activity.	Safely report existing observations and preserve relevant records.
Plan a rescue or negotiate with a person making threats.	Do not improvise rescue or negotiation activity.	Activate the approved emergency response as safely as possible and follow appropriate direction.
Declare a venue secure or a person safe without the required evidence.	Do not give unsupported assurance.	State verified facts, sources, times and outstanding specialist decisions.

The exclusions identify the role taught, not a complete account of every person's legal rights in every emergency. In immediate danger, prioritise safety and appropriate help. Do not interpret the course as a demand to remain in danger while waiting for a specialist, or as permission to perform specialist tactics after an internal email approval.

2.6.5 Control-room acceptance and the boundary of a promise

An independent provider needs a defined mandate. The EA should know the authorised service contact, how a task is accepted, the relevant coverage and the fallback route. The fact that a room is staffed does not prove that a particular executive activity is covered. The fact that a system displays a location does not prove that a responder is travelling to the person.

Use precise status terms. A request may have been received, referred, accepted or completed. A response provider may have been contacted, accepted a dispatch, given an estimated arrival or actually arrived. Do not convert an earlier stage into a later one for reassurance. The research treats these as separate events because they establish different facts. [R1, sections 6-7]

If the control room cannot accept a task, the EA must not simply re-label it as covered or quietly assume responsibility for live monitoring. Refer the gap to the appointed duty or risk owner, identify what remains uncovered and request a workable arrangement. The absence of a solution should remain explicit until it is addressed or transferred through the approved process.

Reflection 6. A venue is booked and the EPO is available, but the changed monitoring period has not been accepted. What may you accurately report, and which decision remains outstanding?

2.7 Medical assistance and practical competence

2.7.1 A useful role without clinical overreach

The EA's role in this unit is to recognise a request for help, activate appropriate assistance, communicate known facts and support the administrative arrangements needed by the authorised response. It is not to diagnose the cause of an illness, decide whether medication is appropriate or determine whether a person is medically fit to travel. Those substantive judgements belong to competent healthcare professionals. [R1, section 8; R2, EA-02.4]

The distinction should not make the assistant passive. A person does not need a diagnosis in order to seek urgent help for an observed emergency. A report that someone has collapsed at a stated location is useful without a claim about the cause. Contact the appropriate emergency service and available trained assistance, describe the situation and follow competent dispatcher or responder instructions within your capability and safety.

This book deliberately does not teach clinical procedures or substitute a written exercise for practical training. St John South Africa's described e-learning pathway combines online theory with an in-person practical assessment. That is a useful example of the distinction between learning information and demonstrating a practical skill; it is not an endorsement, accreditation claim or the only possible training route. [S3]

An EA who separately holds current first-aid competence should act within that training, the applicable emergency framework and the relevant workplace arrangements. Do not make the EA label a reason to ignore separately established competence, but do not allow it to be assumed. The course assessment must describe the capability actually assessed.

2.7.2 First-aid-kit readiness is an administrative responsibility

A readiness check can establish the named owner of a kit, its approved location, accessibility, the current checklist and reported replenishment needs. The EA may arrange a review or report a missing item through the approved process. These tasks help make the arrangement usable without turning the assistant into the clinical authority for its contents.

Do not independently select medicines, substitute equipment or declare a kit suitable for every activity. The relevant qualified owner should establish the checklist and any special requirements. A travel kit, office kit and specialist protective medical capability are not interchangeable merely because each is called first aid.

A useful record states what was checked, by whom and what remained unresolved. 'Kit location and responsible custodian confirmed; missing item reported to the appointed first-aid lead' is more precise than 'medical readiness complete'. A checked container does not prove that a trained responder is available, that equipment is suitable or that a service covers the destination.

The assistant should also know how to find the approved contact and assistance information when required. The information must be accessible to the right people, not simply stored in an inaccessible folder. Formal tests should be agreed with the responsible services; the EA should not place false emergency calls to make a checklist appear tested.

2.7.3 Emergency help must not wait for routine administration

Suppose a visitor collapses during an executive meeting. The learner should activate appropriate emergency assistance and available trained help as safely as possible, provide the location and known observations, and facilitate the response within the approved process. Do not wait to find the executive's calendar approval, insurance number or purchase authority before seeking essential help.

Administrative work can continue in parallel when it is safe and does not distract from the response. An authorised colleague may locate relevant information, arrange access for responders or inform the designated incident lead. Nobody should imply that help cannot be requested until a form is complete. The workflow must be designed around the person's need, not around the convenience of the record.

This priority does not grant permission to disclose every medical or personal record to everyone nearby. Share essential relevant facts through the appropriate response channel, and obtain specialist or privacy direction for additional disclosure. Avoid public discussion of symptoms, speculation about a condition or circulation of photographs through informal groups.

The same rule applies when the EA is not at the scene. Record who reported what and when; do not present second-hand information as direct observation. Communicate the location and source as accurately as available, and route updates to the appropriate responder or incident owner. Do not diagnose remotely or assure others that the person is fine because a device remains visible.

2.7.4 Requests for reassurance and medical information

Executives may ask an assistant to 'check that I am okay to travel' or 'tell them it is nothing serious'. These requests can combine a legitimate need for arrangements with a clinical judgement the EA cannot provide. Separate the parts: arrange access to an appropriate professional, coordinate appointments and update administrative commitments based on authorised advice. Do not give the clinical conclusion yourself.

If a medical-aid or insurer contact requires information, use the established authorised process and the appropriate information owner. Do not gather a complete health history merely because a claim might be needed later. The EA may support the administration without becoming the person who interprets cover, diagnoses a condition or determines treatment.

Where there is uncertainty, use bounded language: 'Medical advice has been requested; I cannot confirm travel fitness. I will update the arrangements when the authorised advice is available.' This is more reliable than reassuring the executive, host or provider with an unsupported answer.

> **KEY POINT | Help first, within capability**
>
> Activate essential assistance without a routine administrative delay. Describe observations and uncertainty accurately. Clinical decisions and practical treatment require the appropriate competence; this unit does not supply it.

Reflection 7. A visitor needs urgent help, but the organiser asks you to locate insurance details first. Describe the immediate coordination response and the administrative work that may follow without delaying assistance.

2.8 Family liaison, incident communication and records

2.8.1 A familiar contact is not automatically the incident liaison

An EA may know the executive's family and be a natural first point of contact. That familiarity can be helpful, but it does not automatically appoint the assistant as the formal family liaison during an incident. The organisation must identify who coordinates family contact, what may be communicated and how verified updates are obtained. [R1, section 8; R2, EA-02.6]

The assistant can receive a concern, acknowledge its importance and connect the caller to the designated route. Do not promise an update that another person has not agreed to provide, state that everyone is safe without confirmation or speculate about what may have happened. A useful interim response can identify what action has actually been taken and how the next authorised contact will occur.

If Daniel has not been appointed the liaison, he should say so without appearing to withdraw care: 'I have passed your concern to the designated incident contact and am seeking confirmation of the next update. I do not have verified information to add at present.' Where a callback has not yet been accepted, he must not say it is confirmed. The assurance should match the record.

If the EA is formally assigned a bounded liaison task, the assignment should identify the audience, approved information, communication channel, update owner and escalation route. Even then, it does not confer authority to diagnose, negotiate, interpret legal obligations or speak for the whole organisation on every aspect of the incident.

2.8.2 Necessary facts, not blanket silence

The brainstorm's instruction about not sharing incident details was developed in the research into controlled, authorised communication. The intended rule is neither to tell everyone everything nor to refuse all information. A legitimate contact or responder may need specific facts to support safety. The EA must distinguish those facts from speculation and unnecessary disclosure. [R1, section 8]

A well-bounded update identifies the verified fact, its source or responsible owner where appropriate, the action under way and the next communication arrangement. It does not include a medical diagnosis the assistant cannot make, a proposed police tactic, an unverified claim of responsibility or the private information of people not relevant to the recipient's task.

For example, an authorised update might say that emergency assistance has been requested and that the designated liaison will provide the next verified information. It should not say that responders have arrived unless arrival has actually been confirmed. Nor should the word 'incident' be used to imply a specific crime when the cause remains unknown.

This discipline supports humane communication. It is possible to acknowledge worry without pretending to know the outcome. It is also possible to say that information is not yet available without sounding indifferent. Offer the next legitimate connection and keep the commitment accurate.

2.8.3 Formal representation and calling for help are different

Public statements, media interviews, regulatory notifications and formal organisational liaison belong to the designated authorised functions. The EA may coordinate the relevant people, prepare a factual

administrative chronology or route an enquiry. The assistant should not become the spokesperson merely because they answered the telephone first.

The companion guide emphasises designated communication during an incident. In this EA course, that boundary governs formal organisational representation; it must be read alongside the explicit emergency-help outcome. It is not a requirement to obtain spokesperson status before calling emergency services, reporting immediate danger or providing truthful observations to the appropriate authority. [A1, chapter 8; R2, EA-02.7]

A media enquiry is different from an emergency call. With a media enquiry, identify the legitimate contact route and refer without confirming restricted details or offering an unofficial explanation. With an emergency call, provide the necessary known facts through the appropriate service route as safely as possible. With a later formal request for records, involve the designated incident, legal or records owner and follow the applicable process.

Do not obstruct lawful requests, invent legal privilege or promise records you cannot authorise. State your role and the status of the request accurately. 'I am the administrative contact and will connect you to the appointed records owner' is more reliable than attempting to decide a legal disclosure issue at the reception desk.

2.8.4 Preserve records without investigating

An assistant may already hold relevant messages, call notes, itinerary versions or acknowledgement records. Preserve them through the approved process when they may be relevant to an incident. Record the original source and timing accurately, distinguish originals from working notes and avoid changing the underlying material to make it clearer or more favourable.

Preservation does not mean collecting everything that might be interesting. Do not enter private accounts, search devices, follow a person, visit a suspected location or pressure colleagues to supply private records. The companion guide's reporting approach is based on existing information that can be preserved safely and lawfully, not on amateur evidence gathering. [A1, chapters 7 and 9]

A concise chronology should distinguish an observation, a reported claim, an instruction and a completed action. If a time is approximate, say so. If a colleague later corrects a detail, retain the correction and its source. An accurate account can contain gaps; an apparently complete but invented account cannot be relied upon.

Protect the record itself. Use the approved repository and restricted distribution. The fact that information relates to an incident does not make a large informal messaging group an appropriate recipient. The appointed response owners decide what further collection, forensic work or formal transfer is required.

2.8.5 When privacy, care and uncertainty meet

A distressed relative may press for details, a manager may press for reassurance and a reporter may press for a statement. The EA's task is not to satisfy every demand. It is to identify the legitimate need, keep information within the relevant authority and connect the person to the proper source of help or verified information.

Do not assume that withholding information is always the safer decision. Necessary facts may enable an authorised responder to act. Equally, do not assume that distress creates unrestricted entitlement. The approved response structure should help resolve those competing considerations quickly and proportionately.

The learner should practise stating what is known, what is not known and who owns the next update. This is not a formula for avoiding difficult conversations. It is a way to remain useful when the assistant cannot legitimately provide the answer being demanded.

Reflection 8. Explain the difference between an EA calling emergency services, an EA providing a factual witness account and an EA issuing a public statement on behalf of the company. Which role or authority question applies to each?

2.9 Respectful refusal, escalation and recovery

2.9.1 A response that protects both the need and the boundary

A good boundary response is specific, calm and useful. Start by acknowledging the legitimate objective. Explain the precise action you cannot perform, or cannot perform yet. Offer the authorised alternative and identify who must make the decision. State the real status and any safe interim work you can complete.

For example: 'I understand that you want the host to prepare properly. I can send the approved arrival details. I cannot send the complete private profile under the current arrangement. I will refer any additional requirement to the information owner.' The response does not accuse the requester, invent a law or imply that support has stopped.

Avoid lengthy argument when the issue is straightforward. The aim is not to win a debate about whether the executive trusts you. The issue is whether the proposed action is authorised and appropriate. A brief explanation can be more effective than a defensive essay, particularly when it names the person who can resolve the legitimate need.

The wording should fit the situation. A routine booking exception may require an options brief. A sensitive request may require a private referral. A direct threat may require immediate safety and an emergency route rather than an assertive conversation. The course must not make visible refusal or confrontation a compulsory response when it would increase danger.

2.9.2 Examples of bounded language

Request or pressure	A defensible response in the supplied course model
'Send the whole file; we are all on the same team.'	'I can provide the information approved for your task. Please confirm the additional requirement so the information owner can decide the scope.'
'Just mark the venue as secure.'	'I can confirm the booking. The protective decision belongs to the appointed security lead and remains pending.'
'Tell the family it is nothing serious.'	'I do not have a verified basis for that assurance. I will use the approved update from the designated liaison or clinical source.'
'Change the log so the handover looks complete.'	'I will retain the actual sequence and record the correction. I cannot create an acknowledgement that did not occur.'

Request or pressure	A defensible response in the supplied course model
'The senior person has approved it, so skip verification.'	'I can process the authorised request once its required verification is complete. I will bring the timing concern to the correct owner.'
'You know them well; go and find out what is happening.'	'I will report the known facts to the authorised support route. I will not undertake a private investigation or put myself at risk.'

These are examples, not compulsory scripts. Learners should preserve the decision logic while using language appropriate to their workplace and the person's needs. They should not repeat a script when circumstances call for immediate help, an interpreter, an accessible channel or a private conversation.

2.9.3 Escalate to an owner, not to an audience

An escalation should identify the issue, the known facts, the missing authority or condition, the consequence and the decision required. Send it through the appropriate channel to a person who can act, or to the designated fallback if that person is unavailable. Copying a large group is not the same as assigning an owner.

A useful escalation might read: 'The revised monitoring period has been requested but not accepted. The currently accepted period ends before the proposed activity. Please decide the approved cover or alternative arrangement. The change is not being represented as covered.' The record should show the source of these facts and any subsequent acceptance.

A referred request remains a coordination item until the appropriate owner accepts it, it is properly closed or it is transferred under the approved process. This does not make the EA the owner of the specialist outcome. It makes the assistant responsible for accurately representing the referral status and taking the next authorised coordination step.

REQUEST SENT	OWNER ACCEPTS	ACTION OR DECISION	CLOSE OR TRANSFER
The issue and required decision reach the correct route.	A named person confirms the task and any conditions.	The authorised response is recorded with remaining uncertainty.	Completion or accepted handover is evidenced; silence is not closure.

Figure 2.3 - The referral that remains accountable. Original course teaching model; apply the actual mandate and emergency procedure.

For ordinary non-emergency work, maintain the current approved arrangement where appropriate while an unauthorised change remains pending. Do not invent a universal waiting period for every issue. The applicable risk assessment and procedure determine the timing and route. Credible immediate danger follows the emergency process without waiting for this administrative loop.

2.9.4 When the normal approver is part of the concern

A normal line-management route may be inappropriate when the concern involves that manager or executive. The working agreement should identify an alternative route, such as the designated HR, ethics, governance or independent reporting function. The learner must be able to find and use the route in the supplied policy without needing the subject of the concern to approve the report.

Keep the account factual and use a safe channel. Distinguish the words or action from your interpretation. Identify any immediate safety or support need. Do not gather private evidence through unauthorised access, circulate accusations or confront the person as a precondition to reporting.

The organisation should make reporting arrangements credible in practice, but the textbook cannot guarantee an employer's response, anonymity, legal protection or a particular remedy. Where a learner's real situation raises employment or legal issues, appropriate independent professional advice may be necessary. The course's role is to teach recognition, safe referral and accurate reporting, not to adjudicate the dispute.

A direct threat or coercion changes the safety context. Do not treat a person under threat as a rule-breaker who must demonstrate courage by resisting. The companion guide prioritises life safety and safe reporting rather than confrontation. Use the approved support route only when it can be used without increasing danger; do not invent covert techniques in response to a training scenario. [A1, chapters 1 and 8]

2.9.5 When you have already crossed a boundary

Professional recovery starts with acknowledging the real position. If you have sent the wrong attachment, described unconfirmed work as complete or performed a task outside authority, stop any continuing avoidable exposure where safe and permitted, report promptly and follow the designated corrective process. Do not conceal the event or ask others to reconstruct a false approval.

The report should say what happened, when, what may be affected, what is confirmed and what remains uncertain. Avoid exaggerating the harm or minimising it before assessment. Identify existing evidence and its controlled location. Record any steps actually taken without implying that they guarantee containment.

The authorised owner may require a corrected message, a restriction, contact with a recipient, a revised plan or specialist assessment. Perform only the part assigned to you. A request to delete every trace of the mistake is not an adequate incident response. Neither is gathering more private information to prove that the error was harmless.

Once immediate needs are addressed, examine the work design. Was the sharing rule unclear? Was an incorrect attachment easy to select? Was the deputy missing access? Did the process reward a 'complete' label over an accurate status? Improvement should correct the system as well as the individual skill. It should not discourage future reporting.

2.9.6 The daily boundary check

Before confirming a significant action, ask: what exactly am I confirming, what evidence supports it, whose authority applies and what remains unresolved? At the end of an assigned duty period, ask whether any sensitive referral or continuing obligation still needs an owner. These questions connect the boundary unit to ordinary daily coordination.

The objective is not a new form for every interaction. With practice, the questions become part of professional judgement. Formal records should remain proportionate, but uncertainty must not disappear merely because the assistant is busy or the executive wants a quick answer.

Reflection 9. The executive making the questionable request is also your ordinary escalation point. What should an appropriate alternative route achieve, and what should you avoid promising to a colleague who raises the concern?

2.10 The Meridian boundary case

2.10.1 The supplied case and its limits

This is an original fictional composite for learning, not a reported incident or a prediction of a typical working day. It brings several distinct boundary questions together so that the reader can practise applying the same method consistently. No hidden facts should be assumed.

Lindiwe is preparing for an external executive discussion. Daniel coordinates the administrative work. Thandi owns the appointed protective input. Aisha can provide deputy support only for periods she has accepted. The existing Meridian working agreement from LU1 remains in place: Daniel can perform bounded routine administration, but cannot approve specialist decisions, release supplier payments or give himself new information-access rights. [R3, section 1.7]

For this case, the organisation's supplied procedure directs emergency calls to the appropriate local emergency service and its available trained support; formal incident and family communication goes through designated owners. Its information rules permit a limited host briefing but not a complete private-profile release to the venue. No recording or automated-transcription arrangement has been approved for this meeting. These are fictional case instructions, not assertions about an actual NKS client.

The learner's job is to identify the requested action, choose the appropriate response, state the reason, identify the next owner and show a safe alternative. Where a confirmation is not supplied, it remains unknown. The worked developments below are additional case facts introduced at their stated stage, not facts Daniel could assume earlier.

2.10.2 The over-broad host request

The host asks Daniel for the complete executive support file, including emergency and family information, 'so reception will have everything'. Daniel verifies that the request comes from the actual host. This settles identity, but not the scope of disclosure. The supplied rule permits the limited briefing; it does not permit the complete file.

Daniel provides the approved administrative details and asks the host to identify any additional requirement. He refers that requirement, not the entire private profile, to the information owner. His record distinguishes the permitted briefing from the declined over-broad method. He does not assert that the host is malicious or that the information is forbidden in every conceivable emergency.

Worked development: the host confirms that the additional need concerns the arrival entrance and the appropriate on-site contact. The authorised owner approves the relevant narrow information, and Daniel sends it through the approved route. The case does not require any family or health record to be released.

2.10.3 The helpful recording suggestion

A colleague proposes leaving an automated meeting recorder connected while Daniel handles another commitment. Daniel identifies that no arrangement for recording or transcription has been approved for this meeting. He does not conclude that a product's availability establishes lawful use or organisational permission.

He explains the gap and proposes an authorised written minute-taker. The recording proposal can be reviewed separately by the proper owners; it is not switched on first and regularised afterwards. Daniel also avoids presenting the automated participant as evidence that he personally attended.

Worked development: Lindiwe chooses a written record by a nominated colleague who accepts the task under the case's ordinary meeting procedure. The unapproved recording method is not used. This resolves the business need without pretending that the underlying recording questions have been answered universally.

2.10.4 The venue assurance and unaccepted coverage

The executive discussion is proposed to continue at a different venue. Lindiwe indicates her business preference. The organiser asks Daniel to mark the new venue 'secure and fully covered' so that the arrangements can be finalised. Thandi has received the details but has not yet given the required protective decision; the control room has not accepted the changed scope.

Daniel can record the proposed venue and business preference. He cannot give the requested assurance. He asks Thandi for the protective input and sends the monitoring change through the room's accepted request process. He describes both decisions as outstanding rather than using Lindiwe's preference as evidence of their completion.

Worked development: before a final decision is made, Lindiwe chooses to retain the original venue and timing. Daniel confirms with the relevant owners that the previously accepted arrangement remains applicable and records that no revised coverage was claimed. He does not invent an approval for the unused venue simply to complete a checklist.

2.10.5 The private location enquiry

A verified family contact asks Daniel for historical movement information about a private weekend. The contact is concerned, but does not report immediate danger. The supplied information-sharing arrangement does not permit this disclosure. Daniel must not assume that family status establishes an unrestricted right to movement records.

He acknowledges the concern and offers the approved route for contact or support. He does not request an export from the control room, search private accounts or ask Thandi to investigate a family matter informally. If the caller later reports a credible immediate safety concern, that new fact would trigger the appropriate support or emergency process; it would not retroactively authorise a general history export.

The worked case ends this request with a referral, not with a fictional resolution of the private concern. An accurate record can show that a support route was provided and a specific disclosure was not authorised. It cannot claim that the underlying personal issue has been resolved.

2.10.6 The medical event

During the meeting, a visitor collapses. Daniel is present. An organiser says, 'Find the insurance details before calling anyone.' The scenario supplies an observed urgent event; it does not supply a diagnosis. Daniel activates the appropriate emergency service and available trained help as safely as possible, communicates the location and known facts, and follows competent instructions within his capability.

Routine insurance administration does not delay the call. Another authorised person can support access and notify the designated incident lead. Daniel does not diagnose the cause, recommend

medication or offer a clinical reassurance to Lindiwe or the visitor's family. The event does not convert him into the medical decision-maker.

Worked development: the designated incident lead accepts coordination. A responder's arrival is later confirmed and recorded separately from the original request for assistance. The case does not disclose the visitor's diagnosis or outcome. A truthful account need not add medical facts simply to make the story feel complete.

2.10.7 The public statement and the false closure

A media caller asks Daniel to confirm that there was a serious incident involving the executive. The known event concerned a visitor, and no approved public statement has been supplied to Daniel. He refers the enquiry to the designated communications function without repeating or correcting restricted details on his own authority. He records the enquiry through the appropriate route.

Later, someone asks him to make the administrative handover show an earlier acceptance time. Aisha had been named as the potential deputy but had not accepted that earlier period. Daniel retains the real sequence, reports the gap to the designated manager and obtains an explicit current arrangement. He does not backdate acceptance or infer that the control room covered all administrative duties.

Worked development: the duty manager confirms the current responsibility allocation and Aisha accepts a defined period from the recorded time. The gap remains part of the factual review. This later acceptance is useful, but it does not erase the earlier absence of confirmation.

2.10.8 The decision record

Matter	Primary boundary decision	Evidence and next owner
Complete profile requested by host.	Decline the over-broad release under the supplied rule; provide permitted briefing.	Verified host; permitted fields; information owner's narrow approval where needed.
Unapproved automated recording.	Do not activate it; refer the proposal and arrange an authorised alternative.	No recording approval supplied; written minute-taker later accepts.
Revised venue described as secure and covered.	Do not give unsupported assurance; obtain specialist decisions or retain an authorised alternative.	Separate business, protective and monitoring status; original arrangement later reconfirmed.
Private movement-history enquiry.	Decline unauthorised history disclosure; support the legitimate concern through the approved route.	Recipient identity distinguished from entitlement; no invented export or private investigation.
Visitor collapses.	Activate appropriate help without routine administrative delay; do not diagnose or treat beyond competence.	Observed facts, call and response times; designated incident owner; later arrival confirmation.
Media enquiry.	Refer formal public communication to the designated function.	Enquiry recorded; no unsupported statement or private detail released.
Backdated handover requested.	Refuse a false record and escalate the actual coverage gap.	Actual acceptance time, named current owner and preserved correction history.

The table is a compact record, not a substitute for the explanations. A response category must always be tied to a specific action. The legitimate part of a request may proceed while another part remains pending or is declined. The learner should explain those distinctions rather than force the whole case into one label.

2.10.9 What the case demonstrates

Daniel remains useful throughout the case. He prepares the host, arranges a meeting record, coordinates the venue decision, hears a family concern, activates medical assistance and supports handover. He does not need unrestricted powers to perform that work well.

The quality of the work lies in accurate distinctions. Identity is not entitlement. A business preference is not a protective approval. Technical access is not permission. Receipt is not acceptance. Emergency coordination is not clinical judgement. Later correction is not evidence of earlier completion.

These distinctions are the foundation for the rest of the course. LU3 develops programme management; subsequent units deepen communication, travel, privacy, protective coordination and emergency readiness. The boundary method remains the same: define the action, establish the mandate, choose a defensible response and keep legitimate support connected to an accountable owner.

Reflection 10. Identify two requests in the case where one part could proceed while another could not. Explain the different authorities involved and the exact status that should have been recorded.

Practical toolkit

The six tools below are editable teaching templates. Use fictional information first. Workplace versions need the actual mandate, local requirements and controlled contact arrangements. They do not create authority, establish legal compliance or replace emergency procedures. A tool should make the work clearer; it should not collect personal detail that the decision does not need.

Tool 2.1 - My authority and referral card

Prepare this card from a supplied working agreement, not from assumptions about a job title. Refer to controlled documents and role contacts rather than copying live personal details into a public workbook. Review the card when scope, personnel, systems or service arrangements change.

Field	Complete for the supplied role
Current role and mandate	Agreement or policy reference, version, effective period and authorised owner.
I may act independently when…	State the task and its conditions; include cost, time, information and dependency limits where applicable.
Approval is needed when…	Identify the change or condition and the correct decision-maker, including a permitted substitute.
Specialist decisions belong to…	Identify the appointed protection, medical, privacy/legal, finance and incident functions relevant to this role.
Actions excluded from this role	Identify prohibited or unsupported methods and the legitimate alternatives; do not imply that a senior request removes the limit.
Safe fallback and emergency routes	Identify where to find the current routes, including an alternative when the normal approver is involved in the concern.

A completed card should let another authorised assistant understand what is permitted without needing your private explanation. Where the source does not answer a question, mark the gap and request the required clarification. Do not invent a permission to complete the card.

Tool 2.2 - Boundary-decision record

Use one record for each material action being assessed. Split mixed requests so that a permissible administrative task is not confused with a specialist decision or an improper method. Complete the record after activating essential help where immediate danger makes action necessary.

Field	Record or decision
Request and source	What exactly was requested, by whom, when and through which channel? Which elements are only claims?
Immediate safety	Is credible immediate danger reported or observed? What safe emergency action has been taken, if applicable?

Field	Record or decision
Specific proposed action	Write the action in a sentence, identifying the relevant person, information, commitment or operation.
Mandate and conditions	Which current instruction applies? What authority, competence, verification or service condition is established or missing?
Primary disposition	A: independently authorised; B: approval required; C: specialist-owned; D: outside the EA role as taught. Explain why.
Safe alternative	What legitimate assistance can proceed without crossing the boundary? What cannot proceed yet or at all under this mandate?
Owner and follow-through	Who must decide or act? Has the person accepted? What fallback applies if not?
Final status	Record completion, a pending dependency, correction or accepted transfer with actual evidence and time.

A weak record says 'escalated'. A stronger record states which issue reached which role, the decision requested and whether ownership was accepted. The record is not complete merely because all cells contain text.

Tool 2.3 - Information-sharing check

Use this check for a proposed disclosure, not as permission to create a larger file. Refer an unresolved legal or privacy issue to the appropriate owner. In an emergency, provide essential relevant facts through the appropriate response route without turning this form into a delay.

Question	Entry for the specific disclosure
Who will receive it?	Recipient identity, role and verification method. Do not record unnecessary identity-document copies.
What is the legitimate need?	The task, authority or approved purpose that makes the information relevant.
What is necessary?	The limited fields or approved record version, and information that should be excluded.
What rule permits the action?	Current procedure or authorisation, conditions and any unresolved specialist decision.
How will it be shared?	Approved channel, appropriate access and any required acknowledgement.
What status can be claimed?	Requested, approved, sent, received or otherwise confirmed: record only what the evidence supports.

A verified identity cannot fill the purpose field on its own. A legitimate purpose cannot fill an absent authority field by assumption. When the request is over-broad, identify the narrower information or alternative route that would meet the actual need.

Tool 2.4 - A respectful boundary response

Draft a short message using the following prompts. Remove unnecessary explanation and use a private or accessible channel where appropriate. In direct danger, safety and the applicable emergency route take priority over delivering a polished refusal.

Part	Draft your response
Legitimate objective	'I understand that the required result is…'
Exact boundary	'I can do… / I cannot do… under the current arrangement because…'
Authorised alternative	'The appropriate next step is… and the decision belongs to…'
Accurate status	'The task is currently…; the unresolved point is…'
Follow-through	'I will complete the authorised coordination step… and record acceptance or use the designated fallback.'

Worked example: 'I understand that the revised meeting needs to be finalised. I can confirm the booking request, but I cannot describe the new venue as secure or covered before the required decisions. I have referred the protective question to Thandi and the monitoring change to the room's designated route. Both remain pending. I will update the arrangement when the relevant owners respond, or escalate the unresolved timing through the agreed route.'

Tool 2.5 - Referral and coverage-gap note

Use this tool when a specialist referral or continuing support task has no accepted owner. It records the gap without transferring responsibility by implication. Do not insert universal time limits: use the supplied procedure and the actual urgency.

Field	Entry
Continuing task	What remains active, within which approved scope or period?
Current owner and limit	Who currently holds the responsibility, and what is the evidenced end or limitation?
Requested owner	Who has been asked to accept which part of the work? Separate administrative and control-room duties.
Acceptance evidence	What acceptance exists? State 'not yet accepted' where that is the truth.
Consequence and fallback	What gap results, which authorised owner can resolve it and what safe alternative is available?
Resolution or transfer	Record the actual decision, conditions and acceptance time; retain the earlier gap for review.

An unanswered message is not a transfer. The outgoing EA should follow the authorised escalation arrangement rather than silently close the task or privately assume an indefinite duty. The organisation remains responsible for supplying workable cover.

Tool 2.6 - Correction and learning record

Use this tool after a mistake or boundary concern has been reported through the proper route. It does not replace the incident process or authorise an investigation. Keep the record factual and proportionate.

Field	Entry
What occurred	Describe the action, timing and source of the information without blame or speculation.
What is known and unknown	Separate confirmed effects from possible exposure or unresolved consequences.
Immediate authorised action	Record the response actually taken, by whom and with what limits; do not claim guaranteed containment.
Evidence location	Identify existing records and approved storage; do not duplicate sensitive contents unnecessarily.
Correction owner	Identify the responsible person, accepted corrective task and review point.
Prevention and verification	State the process or skill improvement, its owner and how effectiveness will be checked.

Reflection 11. You sent the wrong attachment and cannot establish whether it was opened. What should the correction record say, and what should it avoid claiming?

Reflection 12. Identify one routine action that you should perform without unnecessary escalation when the supplied mandate and conditions are satisfied. Explain how its evidence differs from a request that remains pending.

Practice, reflection and explanatory guidance

A unit practice task: decisions that remain useful

Use a fictional workplace with the same boundaries as Meridian. You have a current working agreement, the case's information-sharing rules and access to the designated role contacts. You do not have additional recording permission, specialist protection authority, payment-release authority or clinical competence through this course.

Prepare a boundary-decision portfolio for the eight situations below. Use Tool 2.2, or a concise equivalent, and provide at least three short communication examples using Tool 2.4. No real employee, family, health or location information is required. Do not act out coercion, contact actual emergency services for the exercise or test a live security arrangement.

Situation	Facts supplied for your decision
P1 - Routine independence	A routine internal administrative meeting can move into a free period. The mandate permits it; no protected time, additional cost or specialist dependency is affected. The relevant participants have confirmed availability.
P2 - The unapproved convenience	A colleague asks you to record a private meeting with an automated note-taker. No recording or transcription arrangement has been approved for this meeting.
P3 - The private enquiry	A verified relative asks for location history to resolve a non-emergency private concern. The sharing rule does not permit that release.
P4 - The specialist shortcut	The organiser asks you to search the new venue and sign that it is secure. The appointed protection lead has not accepted that task.
P5 - Help versus paperwork	A person collapses in the meeting area. You know the location but not the cause. The host asks you to find insurance information before requesting assistance.
P6 - The spokesperson assumption	A journalist asks for a statement and an upset caller asks for medical reassurance. You hold no verified clinical update and have not been appointed the public spokesperson or family liaison.
P7 - False completion	A deputy has not accepted the requested period. A manager asks you to mark the handover complete because it will probably be accepted later.
P8 - Monitoring beyond purpose	A colleague asks you to enter a family member's private account or obtain historical tracking to 'check a suspicion'. No such monitoring or access mandate exists.

For each situation, identify the exact proposed action and its primary category, explain the source of the boundary, state what useful work can proceed, identify the decision or support owner, and record what remains unknown. Where the supplied facts permit independent action, demonstrate that you can act rather than escalate everything automatically.

Explanatory guidance for the practice task

P1 tests justified independence. The stipulated conditions support the routine scheduling action. Perform it, record the current arrangement and communicate the update as required. Do not add a

new approval requirement that the supplied mandate does not contain. If a condition changed, the classification would need review.

P2 tests the separation of ordinary minutes from recording and transcription. Do not activate the unapproved method. Refer it for the necessary review and arrange an authorised written record if available. State that permission is absent for this case, rather than making an unsupported claim that all recording is illegal.

P3 tests identity versus entitlement. A verified relationship does not create the missing sharing authority. Decline the unauthorised history release and offer the appropriate contact or support route. A subsequently reported immediate safety concern would need its own response; it would not justify an unrestricted historical export by assumption.

P4 tests the boundary between administrative coordination and specialist protective work. The requested search and assurance are outside the EA role taught. Obtain the appointed lead's decision or arrange an authorised alternative. Do not carry out the search first or treat a venue booking as a protective sign-off.

P5 tests the priority of essential help. Activate the appropriate emergency route and available trained assistance safely, provide the known observations and location, and follow competent instructions within capability. Do not diagnose, recommend treatment or delay the call for insurance administration. Record later developments only when supplied.

P6 tests two different referrals. The journalist goes to the designated communications function without an unauthorised statement. The distressed caller receives a compassionate connection to the approved liaison or support route without invented medical reassurance. Emergency reporting or truthful observations to the appropriate authority remain distinct from formal spokesperson duties.

P7 tests integrity and accepted ownership. Retain the actual status, escalate the unaccepted cover and obtain an explicit arrangement. Do not backdate or fabricate acceptance. If the instruction itself raises an integrity concern, use the appropriate independent reporting route rather than letting the requester approve their own false record.

P8 tests the distinction between authorised exposure awareness and covert personal investigation. Do not enter private accounts or seek an unauthorised tracking history. Safely report the specific concern through the appointed route. Do not investigate intent, collect unrelated personal material or recruit a provider to perform the same unauthorised act for you.

How to review the evidence

Review the portfolio against all seven EA-02 supporting outcomes, not simply the number of correct labels. A competent response identifies the action precisely, recognises the relevant mandate, keeps legitimate support moving and states a truthful outcome or pending status. It neither oversteps authority nor uses boundaries to avoid necessary emergency action.

Review criterion	Evidence of achievement
Classification and conditions	The learner distinguishes permitted independence, missing approval, specialist ownership and excluded methods; mixed requests are separated.
Calls and monitoring	Ordinary call handling and exposure awareness are not confused with unapproved recording, covert access or personal tracking.

Review criterion	Evidence of achievement
Information handling	Identity, legitimate need, permitted scope and channel are addressed; unnecessary information is not released.
Medical boundary	Essential assistance is activated without routine delay; awareness is not presented as diagnosis or practical qualification.
Protective boundary	The learner does not search, confront, investigate, negotiate, perform tactics or give unsupported assurance.
Correct referral	Incident, family, public and specialist decisions go to the designated owners without blocking emergency contact.
Communication and integrity	The response is respectful, offers a legitimate alternative and preserves actual acknowledgements, uncertainty and corrective history.

A serious unsafe decision requires correction and demonstration again; easy marks on unrelated questions should not offset it. Examples include unauthorised disclosure, fabricated confirmation, private rescue or investigation, and delaying essential help for routine paperwork. The final course's numerical scoring, identity assurance and reassessment administration will be set separately. This book provides practice and explanatory guidance, not a professional licence. [R2, assessment principles]

Guidance for the twelve reflections

Reflection 1 - The complete file

The legitimate need is suitable preparation for the executive's attendance. The proposed method is release of a file containing information beyond that need. Establish the actual recipient, required task, permitted scope and channel. A narrower host briefing may satisfy the task. Do not assume that prior dealings authorise every future disclosure.

Reflection 2 - A mixed request

Separate the actions. Perform the administrative part only when its mandate and conditions are satisfied; refer the specialist part to the appropriate owner. Tell affected people which element is complete and which remains pending. A referral does not make the specialist decision yours or prove that the specialist has accepted the task.

Reflection 3 - Backdating acceptance

Backdating would falsely imply that responsibility had transferred during a period when acceptance was not established. Retain the actual timing, record the gap and correction, and obtain the appropriate current cover. A belief that someone was 'probably watching' is not evidence of an accepted task or its scope.

Reflection 4 - Automated transcription

The method changes what may be captured and processed and may involve an additional service. Check the actual approved arrangement, relevant participants and purpose, information access and

storage, and any required legal or privacy decision. A written minute may be an authorised alternative. Product availability supplies none of those permissions by itself.

Reflection 5 - A verified relative

Identity is established; entitlement to historical movement information is not. Receive the concern respectfully and use the approved support route without providing the unapproved history. Assess any newly reported immediate safety issue through the appropriate procedure. Do not investigate private relationships to decide whether the caller deserves the information.

Reflection 6 - A changed venue

Report the booking, EPO availability and outstanding decisions separately. The changed monitoring period is not accepted merely because the venue exists or the EPO is available. Seek the required input or an approved alternative and show the unresolved coverage explicitly. Avoid the unqualified word 'approved'.

Reflection 7 - Urgent help

Request appropriate emergency assistance and available trained support safely, giving the location and observations. Insurance and other administration may follow through an authorised colleague or after the immediate action; they must not block it. The EA should not diagnose the condition or claim that a response has arrived before confirmation.

Reflection 8 - Three communication roles

An emergency caller supplies essential facts to obtain help. A person giving a truthful account reports what they know, distinguishing observation from hearsay. A spokesperson represents the organisation through an appointed mandate and approved information. The need for a formal spokesperson must not be turned into a ban on reporting immediate danger or giving truthful information to the appropriate authority.

Reflection 9 - An alternative route

The route must allow the concern to reach an appropriate person without requiring approval from the person implicated. Use safe, factual and proportionate reporting and seek support. Do not promise anonymity, legal protection, a guaranteed outcome or complete secrecy. Do not require confrontation or private evidence gathering before referral.

Reflection 10 - Useful partial progress

The host can receive the approved briefing while the over-broad private-file release is declined. A written minute-taker can be arranged while recording remains unapproved. The distinction depends on the actual case permissions, not a general preference for one format. State the authority and evidence for each component.

Reflection 11 - A misdirected attachment

Record what was sent, when, to whom and what is known about subsequent actions. State that opening or further distribution is unknown if that is the evidence. Report through the approved route,

preserve relevant records and follow assigned corrective instructions. Do not assert successful containment merely because a recall was requested.

Reflection 12 - Appropriate independence

A routine task that meets the current mandate and all relevant conditions should be completed without a newly invented approval barrier. Evidence should show the performed task and required communication. A pending request instead shows the missing decision or condition, its owner and the next authorised follow-up. Accuracy supports both independence and restraint.

Unit summary and key terms

Boundaries make the executive-support partnership dependable. They connect useful initiative to actual authority, appropriate competence, necessary information and truthful evidence. A capable EA does not respond to every request with either an automatic yes or an automatic no. The professional response identifies the legitimate need, separates the proposed actions and keeps appropriate support moving.

Use the four categories as a thinking aid: act independently where authority and conditions are established; obtain the correct approval where a legitimate action is not yet authorised; refer specialist judgement to the appointed owner; and decline an action outside the EA role as taught while supporting a legitimate alternative. Credible immediate danger calls for safe emergency assistance without routine administrative delay.

Apply the same discipline to information, technology and communication. Access is not permission. Identity is not entitlement. An automated tool does not create a lawful or approved use. A venue booking is not a security assessment. A tracking signal is not confirmed welfare. A sent message is not accepted ownership. Formal liaison authority does not prevent an ordinary person from requesting emergency help.

When a boundary is challenged, be specific and respectful. When the ordinary approver is involved in the concern, use the appropriate alternative route. When an error has occurred, report and correct the real position rather than rewriting it. The purpose is to protect people, preserve trustworthy information and support reliable work.

Term	Meaning used in this unit
Authority	Permission to decide or act within a defined scope and conditions.
Competence	The capability needed to perform an activity to its required standard.
Mandate	The defined responsibilities, limits and permissions of a role or service.
Access	Ability to reach information, a system, a place or a person; not proof of permission to use it for every purpose.
Boundary	The limit or condition that distinguishes permitted action from work requiring another decision, role or method.
Delegation	An authorised allocation of specified work or decisions; it does not transfer unlimited powers.
Legitimate need	A relevant task or authority supporting a particular information request, subject to applicable rules.
Verification	The approved process for checking a claimed identity, instruction or fact.
Disclosure	Sharing specified information with a recipient; its authority, scope and channel must be considered.
Exposure awareness	Authorised recognition and reporting of relevant information disclosure, not covert personal investigation.

Term	Meaning used in this unit
Specialist-owned action	A substantive judgement or activity belonging to an appointed competent function.
Escalation	Bringing a defined issue to an appropriate decision or response owner through an authorised route.
Acknowledgement	Evidence that a defined message, task or update has been accepted in the way the process requires.
Uncertainty	Information that has not been established and must not be silently presented as fact.
Formal liaison	An appointed communication role with a defined audience, purpose and information authority.
Duress	Pressure associated with a threat of harm; a safety context requiring support rather than a test of resistance.
Correction history	A record of what changed, why and when, without disguising the earlier state.
Accepted handover	A defined transfer of continuing responsibilities to a named incoming owner who accepts them.

The next unit develops planning and managing the executive's programme. It builds on the partnership from LU1 and the boundaries established here. The objective remains a capable assistant who can organise real work, make uncertainty visible and coordinate the right decisions without becoming a substitute specialist.

References and further reading

Project sources and continuity

[R1] NKS Capital. Executive Assistant: Research Foundation and Development Brief, version 1.0, 6 October 2026. Project research, especially sections 6-10. The accepted role model and safe boundaries are the principal content foundation. The report distinguishes desk research from validated operational service design.

[R2] NKS Capital. Executive Assistant: Course Learning Outcomes, version 1.0, 6 October 2026. EA-02 and EA-02.1 to EA-02.7, associated evidence, quality standard and assessment principles. Outcome wording is retained; the explanation, case developments and tools in this manuscript are original curriculum material.

[R3] NKS Capital. The Professional Executive Assistant and the Executive Partnership, Learning Unit 1, version 1.0, 6 October 2026. Sections 1.5-1.9 establish the working agreement, Meridian characters, responsibility distinctions and accepted handover. Financial limits, hours and permissions in that case remain fictional.

[A1] Tiger Kidnapping in Telecommunications: Executive and Family Awareness Guide, first edition 2026, supplied project reference. Chapters 1, 2, 7-9. Used for people-first awareness, safe factual reporting and non-investigative boundaries. Its Zimbabwe-specific context is not a universal legal or emergency procedure. No source artwork or long passages have been reproduced.

Limited external verification

The following public sources were checked on 6 October 2026 for the specific contextual points cited. They do not endorse NKS Capital or confer compliance, accreditation, legal permission or practical competence. The manuscript is not a complete legal review. Before workplace release, obtain appropriate legal/privacy, medical and operational review of the relevant local instructions.

[S1] Republic of South Africa. Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013, Information Regulator reference copy. Sections 9-22, 26-35 and 72 identify relevant processing, special-information and cross-border issues. Used for limited context, not a determination of the legal basis for any proposed NKS service.

Official source: inforegulator.org.za

[S2] Republic of South Africa. Regulation of Interception of Communications and Provision of Communication-Related Information Act 70 of 2002, Department of Justice reference copy. Sections 2 and 4-6. Used to distinguish a statutory prohibition with conditional exceptions from a blanket recording rule. The copy bears a May 2025 download date; current application, amendments and commencement must be checked by the relevant legal owner before implementing a recording arrangement.

Official source: www.justice.gov.za

[S3] St John South Africa. e-Learning First Aid Training Online. Public description of online theory and an in-person practical assessment. Used only to illustrate the distinction between awareness/theory and separately assessed practical skills. No price, course duration or qualification equivalence is adopted here.

Official source: stjohn.org.za

[S4] Department of Employment and Labour. Employment and Labour warns of confidentiality when dealing with harassment cases, 1 September 2022, South African Government publication. Limited context on confidentiality alongside measures to protect safety and dignity; not an adjudication of a workplace complaint or a complete statement of available remedies.

Official source: www.gov.za

Keeping the publication and operational supplement separate

The public book contains general methods, fictional examples and reusable tools. Actual role permissions, contacts, service coverage, information-processing instructions, escalation thresholds and confidential alert arrangements belong in a separate controlled supplement. Its responsible owners must maintain and approve it. Reader exercises should never require live executive, family, health or tracking records.